

JSS 2 NIGERIAN HISTORY – FIRST TERM

TOPIC 2: FIRST REPUBLIC (1963–1966)

1. Becoming a Republic

On 1 October 1963, Nigeria became a republic. The Governor-General was replaced by a President (ceremonial head of state). Dr Nnamdi Azikiwe became the first President. The Prime Minister (Tafawa Balewa) remained head of government.

2. Main Political Parties and Leaders

- **NPC** (Northern People's Congress) – dominant in the North; associated with Sir Ahmadu Bello and Tafawa Balewa.
- **NCNC** (National Council of Nigerian Citizens) – strong in the East; associated with Nnamdi Azikiwe.
- **AG** (Action Group) – strong in the West; associated with Obafemi Awolowo.

Coalitions and alliances shifted; regional competition was intense.

3. Achievements

Establishment of republican institutions, expansion of education and infrastructure in some regions, Nigeria's active role in African affairs and the Commonwealth.

4. Problems

Ethnic and regional rivalry, census controversies, election crises (especially 1964–65), Western Region crisis, corruption allegations, and weakening of national unity. These tensions contributed to the collapse of the First Republic.

5. Summary

The First Republic (1963–1966) had Azikiwe as President and Balewa as Prime Minister. Achievements were overshadowed by regional conflicts and political crises that ended in military intervention.

End of Topic 2